

THE ENTERPRISE MARKETER'S FUTURE-PROOF LINK BUILDING STRATEGY *EARNING*



SEARCH ENGINE OPTIMIZATION
IN A POST-PENGUIN 2.0 WORLD



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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Off-page signals are the most influential elements in leading search engine algorithms. This won't change, so we build links. But ranking on search engines is just one of the ways links build value: referral traffic, social media conversations and online community building are all positive side effects from a well-crafted link building campaign. The world of link building evolves every year, and 2013 is no exception. The latest release of Google's Penguin 2.0 update promises to tighten filters even more for websites that don't align with Google's future vision and to reward those that do.

That reward for aligning with search engine technology is a link building strategy that is future-proof. This strategy develops a greater volume, a wider variety and a higher quality of links at the lowest cost to your marketing team. This strategy also enables teams to achieve ROI faster by driving six other short-term digital marketing returns in addition to more search traffic. These short-term returns include:

- **Link referral traffic**
- **Social media buzz**
- **Community growth**
- **Opt-in email list growth**
- **Retargeting network reach**
- **Brand awareness**

While you might think this sounds great, it may also sound like a significant tactical shift. But the fact is that organizations experienced in link building won't notice a major change. Those who are great at earning link placements just need to develop and use high-quality content in the process. Others who are already adept at creating quality content need only use a more targeted link research and outreach process.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY [continued]

This ebook will present two concepts that serve key roles in this future-proof link building strategy:

Contribution: A noteworthy piece of content that contributes value to online media outlets, communities and blogs a target audience frequents. These are commonly educational pieces of media that inform, educate and entertain the target audience. Examples include white papers, ebooks, guides, mobile apps and videos.

Earned Media Strategy: The research, production and promotion of a high-value contribution. As traditional off-page SEO tactics evolve into a form of digital PR, the once-successful practice of “link building” will morph into “link earning.” A successful earned media strategy earns hundreds powerful links, search traffic and the other six short-term digital marketing returns mentioned above.

Use the processes and information in this ebook to drive future-proof SEO results at a lower cost and in a shorter timeframe. Your rankings—and your business—could depend on it.

PART 1:

Insights into Future-Proof Link Earning

The most recent Panda and Penguin updates were the biggest updates in Google's history. These two updates helped Google realize the dream it has always chased, which is filtering out shallow content and weak links.

Panda and Penguin have guided the evolution of SEO strategies into what now looks like content marketing and digital public relations. Post-Panda and Penguin, organizations can earn organic search visibility with quality content promoted on high-quality websites without worrying about spammers cheating the system and cutting in line.

1



4 Insights Into What Google Really Wants

In a recent [video](#), Google's webspam team head Matt Cutts explained the upcoming goals of his team, what actions to avoid and what actions Google wants to reward. The following four insights, taken straight from the video, illustrate how contributions can help your organization deliver exactly what Google wants.

The Google logo, consisting of the word 'Google' in its characteristic serif font, with a trademark symbol (TM) to the upper right. The logo is centered within a white rounded rectangle with a dark border.

Insight #1: SEO Based On Quality Content is Future-Proof

Adding quality content to a link building strategy shouldn't be a major change for most SEO teams that are building links in a credible and authentic way. The biggest change to embrace will be building links to a value-added contribution rather than to a service, product or category page.

“If you’re doing high quality content when you’re doing SEO, then this [Penguin 2.0] shouldn’t be a big surprise. You shouldn’t have to worry about a lot of different changes.”

– Matt Cutts

“If you don’t have a linkable asset, now is the time to start working on one because they earn more links than anything else.” – Cyrus Shepard, SEOmoz, Whiteboard Friday

However, your team will need to master great content creation if that’s not a skill set you currently have. The importance of quality content can’t be stressed enough.

But even the best content in the world doesn’t get discovered automatically, so an outreach effort is still necessary. A smart and targeted earned media placement strategy will get the digital PR wheel turning and catalyze a cascade of links following a high-quality media placement. But remember: these top media placements are only possible with a quality contribution as the centerpiece of the campaign.

Quality content, on- and off-page, is a future-proof SEO strategy.

Insight #2: Google's Goal is to Promote Authoritative Websites

“We’re doing a better job of detecting when someone is more of an authority on a specific space. You know, it could be medical. It could be travel. Whatever. And try(ing) to make sure that those rank a little more highly if you’re some sort of authority ... we think might be a little more appropriate for users.”

– Matt Cutts

One of the primary objectives of SEO practitioners has been to drive as much traffic as possible from authoritative websites. Google has made a shortlist of these authoritative websites, calling them Hilltops.

Earning links from Hilltops in your industry requires authority on two fronts. First, the link pointing to content that resides on your website must be a high-quality and valuable contribution. The second front is to match the topical relevance of your content with the Hilltop that links to your contribution. If your campaign addresses both of these issues, earning links from many of your industry’s most authoritative sites becomes a reality.

Earning links from multiple industry Hilltops can develop your website into an industry authority as well. Cutts makes it clear that Google wants these websites to “rank a little more highly” than the rest. This means the tide will rise across your entire website, not just the pages involved in the link earning campaign.

Climbing Hilltops in your industry is a future-proof SEO strategy.

Insight #3: You Can't Buy a Ticket to the Hilltop

“If someone pays for coverage or pays for an ad or something like that, those ads should not flow PageRank ... we’ll be looking at some efforts to be a little bit stronger on our enforcement as far as advertorials that violate our quality guidelines.” – Matt Cutts

Paid relationships have always been at the top of the list of violations of Google search guidelines. As efforts to squash paid link networks continue to evolve, websites that pay for placements with followed links will continue to suffer penalties.

SEO practitioners want to build links that add value for a lifetime. Paid relationships are certain to end up in Google’s link disavow tool at some point. It’s like a shot clock in basketball that always ends in a violation—it’s just not worth it.

Earning links, rather than buying links, is a future-proof SEO strategy.

Insight #4: Contributions Can Help You Recover From Panda

“We are looking at Panda and seeing if we can find some additional signals, and we think we’ve got some to help refine things for sites that are kind of in the border zone ... if we can soften the effect a little bit for those sites that we believe have some additional signals of quality, that will help sites that were previous affected ... to some degree.” – Matt Cutts

Insight #4: Contributions Can Help You Recover From Panda (continued)

Contributions that earn high-quality media placements drive a more diverse set of digital signals than any other tactic in SEO. These digital signals include:

Social mentions

Facebook, LinkedIn, Twitter, G+, Pinterest, Digg, reddit

Middle-of-the-pack DA website links

Articles on industry communities and blogs

News curation websites

Paper.li, Scoop.it

News aggregation websites

Huffington Post, Alltop

News feed syndication

Private companies and public organizations

Print publications

Contributions receive permission for print or use in magazines and trade publications

Slideshows

Slideshare, PDFs

Having a wide variety of digital signals pointing to your website communicates trust and authority to search engines. Since these signals are earned naturally, search engine algorithms analyze link growth timestamps for authenticity, which will also progress naturally. The wide variety of signals listed above will help sites that have been affected by Google's Penguin update.

Driving a variety of quality digital signals is a future-proof SEO strategy.

Why We Build Links

High-quality referrals are the base measurement of popularity, relevance and authority—in both human networks and digital networks. Day in and day out, SEOs work hard to build links to convince search engine algorithms their links are the most relevant and authoritative resources for the products and services they sell.

Earning Online Referrals

High-power referrals in human networks assign credibility and respect that open doors for opportunities. High-power links in online networks assign authority that results in higher search engine visibility. Rand Fishkin of SEOmoz describes the quantifiable value of these high-power links as “link juice.” It’s the flow and distribution of link juice from authoritative sources that earn credibility online and drive visibility in organic search engine results.

Authoritative Industry Hilltops

The release of Penguin 2.0, along with every other search engine update, puts algorithms one step closer to realizing the end goal: awarding search visibility to genuinely relevant, valuable and authoritative resources. To do this, Google uses Hilltop, “a novel ranking scheme for broad queries that places the most authoritative pages on the query topic at the top.” Since search is a zero-sum game, authority has to be started somewhere. This is why Hilltop operates on a special index of expert documents, which are simply a small number of websites that have been deemed authoritative by Google.

The Hilltop algorithm works by connecting the index of topically relevant “expert documents” to other pages through the link graph. By being associated in the link graph to Hilltops, an organization becomes a Hilltop itself. Being closely tied to industry Hilltops drives long-term search engine visibility.

Why We Build Links [continued]

Contributions + Earned Media Climbs Hilltops

Developing and promoting a relevant, valuable and authoritative content resource can enable you to climb these Hilltops. Contributions certainly require more upfront effort to create a piece of content worthy of climbing a Hilltop. Worthy contributions require research, creativity and skillful copywriting before the first link is earned. You'll have the resources to climb the Hilltop if your organization puts in the work to develop a worthy contribution

Can You Climb the Hilltop?

Are you willing to develop and promote valuable contributions that enhance link building efforts by earning a cascade of links and a wide variety of other digital signals? If so, this strategy will deliver more by doing less, and will drive short-term returns that will supplement and amplify the ROI from long-term organic search visibility.



PART 2:

Contributions + Earned Media Scales Inbound Links Naturally and Without Scaling Cost

Scaling link building has historically been the most difficult, costly and time-consuming part of SEO. Link building tactics must also change every year due to search engine updates. There now exists an alternative to the costly, low-scale and constantly changing world of link building.

An earned media campaign with a valuable contribution is a strategy that finally allows SEO marketers to scale link building in a natural way without scaling costs. The result is a lower cost per link and a higher impact in search. This is achieved through a top-down strategy of seeding the market with a few high-quality earned media placements with large, relevant and targeted audiences that will interact with and share your content. These authoritative and topically relevant media placements will drive more links than any manual effort could possibly achieve for the same cost and timeframe.



Scaling Link Earning by Developing Contributions

Contributions aren't a one-hit wonder. Organizations that climb Hilltops realize a reputational gain that pays off with increased search engine visibility. The boost in search engine results isn't just for the pages that earn the links, but across the entire website. Google and other search engines want to promote Hilltops across all relevant topics.

Contributions scale link-earning efforts and search engine visibility in a natural way that's future-proof. It's a future-proof strategy because it goes back to the search engine's vision of authority since day one—to create great content that people want to link to naturally.

Higher-Quality Links

Who would you rather promote: your buddy's garage band or the Foo Fighters? That's the difference between building links for product pages and building links to contributions. Convincing top media outlets to link to a high-quality contribution is a pitch that sells itself.

There is much more upfront effort involved with the contribution strategy, but this effort will pay off by making the earned media placement easier to get. The contribution must be:

- **High-quality content**
- **Valuable to a specific target audience**
- **Educational and entertaining**



More Links at a Lower Cost

An earned media campaign built around a contribution drives a large volume of links from a variety of sources including:

Social mentions

Facebook, LinkedIn, Twitter, G+, Pinterest, Digg, reddit

Middle-of-the-pack DA website links

Industry communities and blogs

Industry news aggregators and curation platforms

Huffington Post, Alltop, Paper.li, Scoop.it

RSS syndication

News feeds

Private companies, public libraries

Print publications

Contributions receive permission for print or use in magazines and trade publications

Slideshows

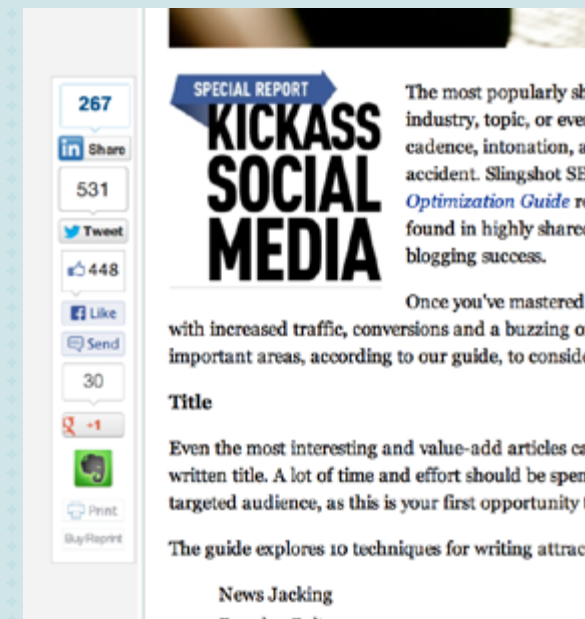
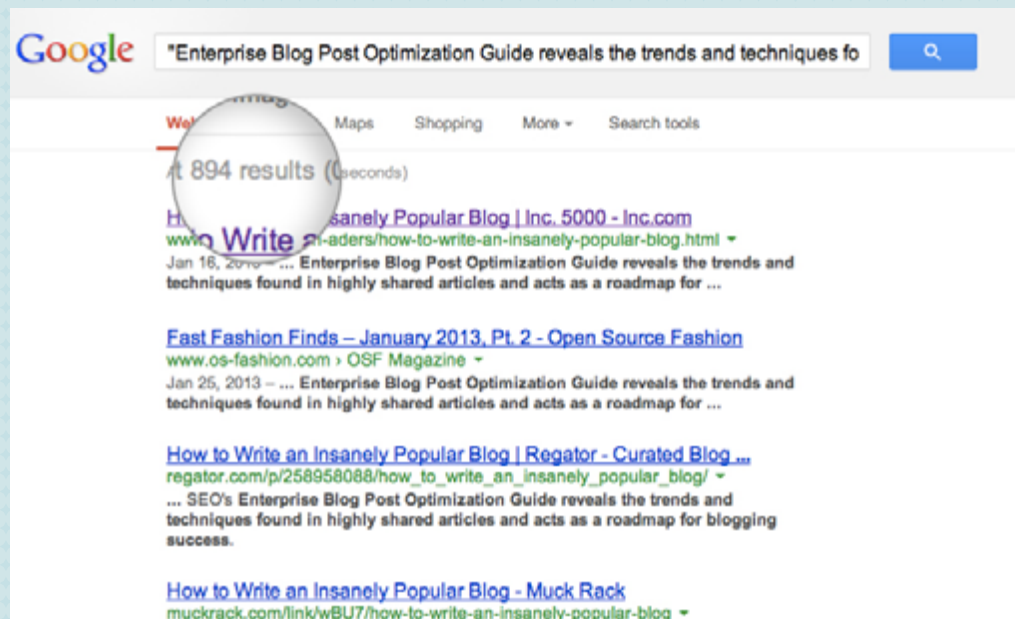
Slideshare, PDFs

Trying to build all of these signals on your own would be an extremely costly and time-consuming endeavor. Furthermore, most of the link types—like social mentions, RSS syndications, news aggregators and news feeds—simply can't be built manually. You can be sure that these link types are some of the most valuable signals to search engines.

More Links at a Lower Cost (continued)

A contribution strategy is the most effective way to scale the volume and variation of digital signals, resulting in a more diverse link profile and a significant reduction in cost.

An article I wrote for Inc.com, “[How to Write an Insanely Popular Blog](#),” serves as an example of a contribution campaign. The article was syndicated from a wide variety of the web properties mentioned above approximately 894 times. In addition the campaign drew over 1000 social mentions, which was multiplied further through Retweets and shares on social networks. Imagine what kind of link building effort it would take to attain similar results. Considering that the average cost to build one guest article link is roughly \$1,000, this campaign required around \$50,000 in marketing resources and only 1/10th the effort.



PART 3:

How Contributions Drive Returns in the Same Quarter

The 6 Short-Term Bonus Returns

As marketers, we want returns on our tactical investments as quickly as possible. Organizations that are successful in organic search know from experience that this doesn't happen overnight. Top media outlet exposure from a contribution and earned media campaign will generate organic search results, but it still takes time. New links, especially from "middle-of-the-pack" domain authority websites, can take anywhere from 30 to 90 days before they are indexed by search engines. But what if there was a way to drive long-term SEO success along with short-term digital marketing returns?

One of the most attractive benefits of the contribution strategy is the wide variety of short-term returns that begin the moment the earned media placement is published.



Return #1: Referral Traffic

The contribution campaign is a top-down, scaled approach to building links to great content. The fact that the linked content is valuable and interesting to the market has a two-fold benefit. First, it will make building the top-tier media links much easier since the content has value to the publication that gets the pitch. Second, these publications are specifically targeted for the reader bases that will be interested in the content, so these links drive highly targeted referral traffic [one of the highest converting website traffic segments].

Referral traffic is then scaled through the cascade of links that follow the publication of the contribution. Links from social media, the blogosphere, news curators and aggregators, RSS syndications, slideshows and PDFs all drive additional referral traffic to the website. Since the content is valuable and appears on newsworthy websites, the majority of these links are earned in the short term. And over the long term, the contribution remains as an evergreen piece of content that earns traffic and links as long as the content is on the Web.



Return #2: Opt-in Email List Growth

“What we’re trying to do with all forms of marketing is tie interests to actions. We assume that some percentage of the people seeing your smoke signal are indeed in the market for a new horse, and when we link interest and action to create a prospective customer, we call that ‘filling the top of the funnel.’” – Jay Baer, *Youtility*

The number one challenge in email marketing is building opt-in email lists of people in your target persona groups. Contribution campaigns drive demand for content from your organization and provide visitors the opportunity to opt in for more updates and resources when engaging with contributions.

Most email list growth strategies rely on using every page of a website to ask people to join. There is no better time to present opt-in email subscription opportunities than when visitors come to your website with interest in your content. A contribution gives these visitors a genuine reason to sign up to receive more valuable content from your organization.



Return #3: Social Media Buzz

“...by and large, Google is trying to end the practice of link building and renew the practice of link earning. I think that’s why you see so many SEOs embracing content marketing...” – Rand Fishkin, SEOMoz, Whiteboard Friday

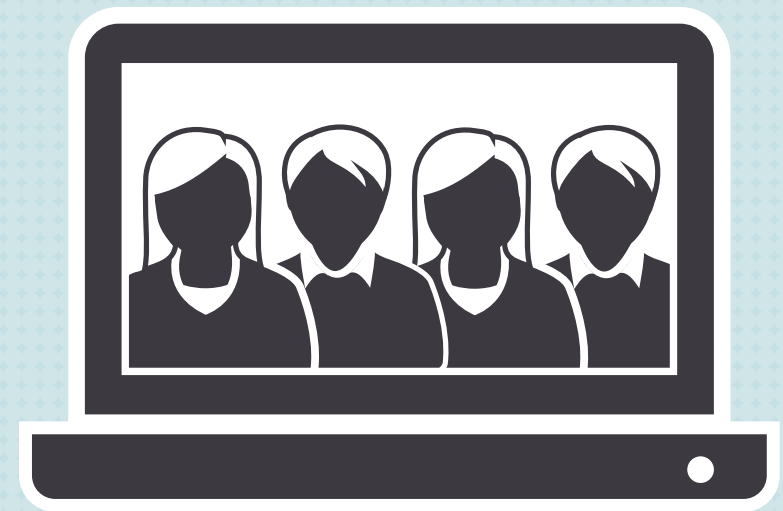
The social media influencers in your industry read the same online media, blogs, publications and community content that your prospects do. The right earned media placements fuel conversations in social media, since news attracts more syndication on social networks than any other topic.

This social media buzz drives referral traffic from social networks and creates more quality and authority signals for search engines. The short-term referral traffic works as a bonus return while the signals build relevance and authority for long-term search engine visibility.



Return #4: Online Community Growth

Attracting and maintaining a vibrant online community is the *ne plus ultra* of digital marketing. Whether you sell services, products or software, an online community will add tremendous value to your organization. Contribution campaigns are excellent at driving target audience members to join your online community. Online communities don't need fancy sub-sites or existing communities with thousands of members—they just need engaging, useful content they can read and share.



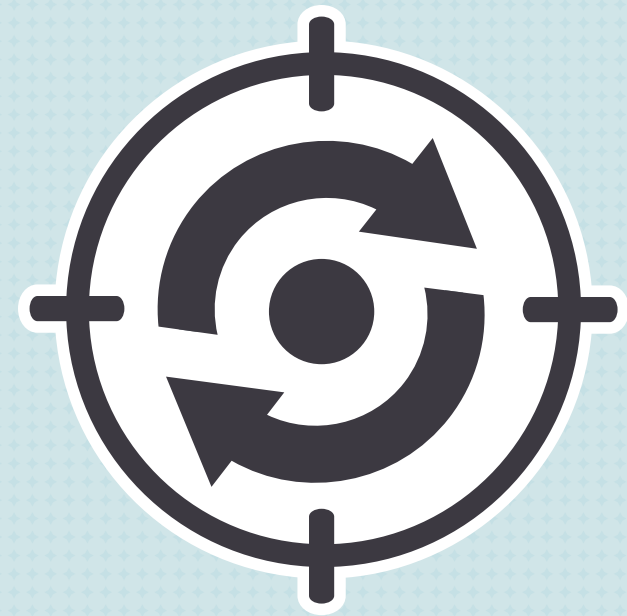
Return #5: Retargeting Network Reach (without paying for impressions!)

The two metrics that retargeters care about are network reach, audience growth and lead score. The earned media strategy enhances both of these metrics.

Retargeting campaigns extend network reach by purchasing banner ads. However, there is a ceiling to network reach since exposing a lead to too many retargeted banner ads has a negative effect.

This is where earned media contributions add a ton of value for retargeters. An earned media campaign earns hundreds of links from a variety of online sources, which increases retargeting network reach without having to pay for impressions and clicks. Referral traffic from these sources also grows retargeting audiences in the short-term.

Contribution campaigns that earn media placements put your content in front of a highly targeted audience on a variety of websites. This high-value content increases trust and familiarity with your brand better than any banner ad ever could. Enhanced brand engagement through contributions results in higher retargeting visitor scores and ushers these visitors closer to converting on your retargeting ads. Extending network reach and increasing lead scores through quality contributions is much more effective than using banner advertisements.



Return #6: Online Brand Awareness

Add up the prior five returns and you'll appreciate the impact a successful earned media placement will have on overall brand awareness and acceptance. We refer to brand awareness and acceptance as "digital relevance." Achieving digital relevance online is the result of a cohesive strategy that drives a variety of synergistic returns. The qualitative impact from increased brand awareness, along with the quantitative impact from search engine signals, results in the highest returns in SEO.

Many of the seasoned SEO practitioners reading this book may be thinking this all sounds like unicorns and rainbows! So before we get to the next section, where we'll show you exactly how the contribution and earned media processes work, we'd like to share the story of how we stumbled across this strategy, as told by digital**relevance** co-founder Kevin Bailey.



STUMBLING UPON THE EARNED MEDIA CONTRIBUTION STRATEGY

By Kevin Bailey



The future of link building was never so clear to me as when SEOmoz founder Rand Fishkin pointed to his first slide at HubSpot's Inbound '12 conference.



The logo in the lower-right corner of the graph was that of our sister company, Slingshot SEO.

The graph was

ours, too. Rand was making the argument that we should worry more about search engine traffic than search engine rankings, but that was beside the point. He had just promoted our latest study directly to our target market, and we didn't pay him a penny or even ask him to do it. What

began as an SEO campaign for topical relevance was now driving real offline value in addition to volumes of search engine traffic.

Our web analytics lit up with inbound links, social signals and traffic once again, as it had over and over since we promoted the study nearly a year ago. To us, this study showing the organic clickthrough rates on Google was nothing remarkable; it was based on our own search campaign data we had been collecting for years. All we did was compile the data into a downloadable study. But to our industry, the data completed a critical formula needed to forecast the value of SEO.

The links, social mentions, leads and brand awareness generated from this study were unlike anything we'd ever experienced. Our initial outreach attempts had the most reputable Hilltops in our industry fighting over who got to

release it first. We ended up giving first-release rights to SEOmoz, followed by many other search industry Hilltops that accepted our guest articles without hesitation.

Nearly every secondary blog and media outlet linked directly to the study, since it was a downloadable PDF on our website. Links and referral traffic poured in. Nearly half the visitors exchanged their names, company information and emails to access our contribution. We figured it was a fair exchange, considering how much we were helping marketers solve a significant problem.

Search engine rankings for keywords across the board

shot up as our brand became far more relevant in the eyes of Google. This link-earning campaign drove more value for Slingshot SEO than any prior marketing campaign in company history. This was the moment we realized that link earning with industry contributions and earned media was the future of link building.

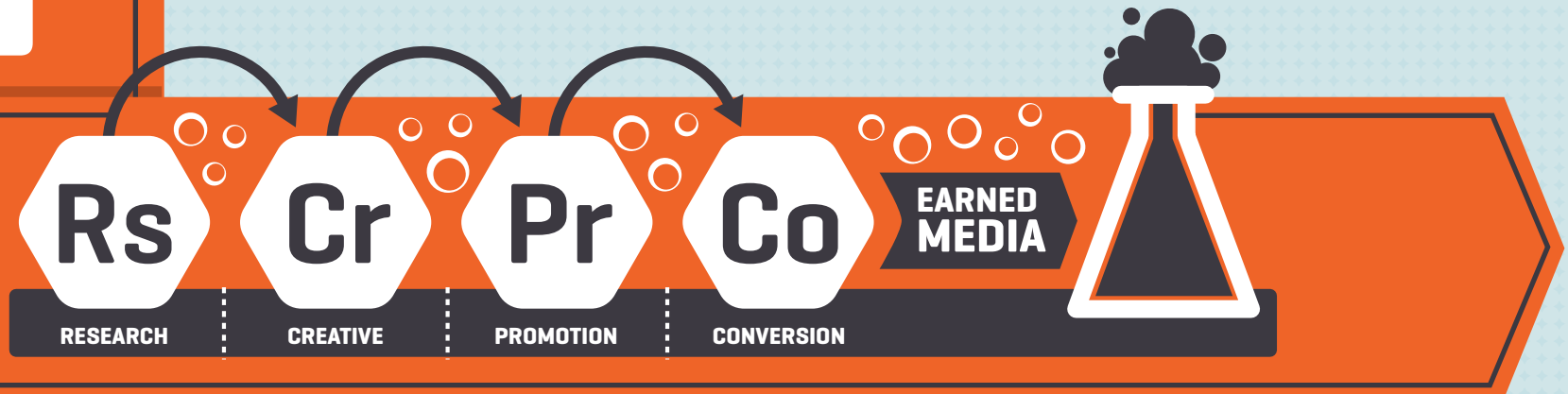
We spent the next year developing and honing the strategies you're about to read. Integrate these processes into your link-earning strategies and start achieving the same success for your organization.



PART

4

THE EARNED MEDIA PROCESS



TODAY'S

“BIG IDEAS”

ARE POWERED BY

BIG DATA



RESEARCH

Earned media campaigns are highly targeted efforts that require a complete understanding of customer personas. An efficient research process is necessary to gather the knowledge required to develop remarkable content that will educate, inform and entertain a target audience. Online media outlets, blogs, digital communities and social media influencers must find genuine value in the content in order to earn the powerful media placements that fuel an earned media campaign.



Rs

Online Target Persona Discovery

More than likely, target market persona research already has been performed by most companies' marketing departments. If so, this is a great starting point for the research process. Persona profiles in print or other traditional media are different from their online counterparts, so there is a bit of "conversion" necessary to turn traditional personas into online personas. Use tools to discover and define target online personas, such as:

- **GOOGLE ANALYTICS**—Discover the highest valued personas currently active on owned web properties.
- **EXPERIAN HITWISE**—View audience demographic data from the most popular properties on the Internet.
- **GOOGLE ADWORDS KEYWORD TOOL**—Find the most popular keywords target personas are interested in.
- **OPEN SITE EXPLORER**—Uncover connections between popular media outlets and corporate web properties.



Online Target Persona Discovery (continued)

Combining data from these tools will help build better target persona profiles. The goal is to procure actionable information about target personas, such as:

- **Where do they hang out online?**
- **What content do they consume and share on a regular basis?**
- **How are they entertained?**
- **Where do they receive ongoing education?**

Answering these questions will lay the groundwork for success in the creative, promotion and conversion phases of the earned media process.



Rs

Idea Generation for Centerpiece Content

The last phase of the research process is to define the centerpiece content that will be the focal point of the earned media campaign. If earlier research was diligently performed, idea generation for creative should be very straightforward.

For example, if research has discovered the social networks top online media prospects frequent and the top content they digest and share on those networks, focus is quickly narrowed to certain types of content. Better yet, top contributors and community managers on those online properties can be contacted to discuss ideas for new content, setting the stage for promotion. It is important to make these types of contacts to help with design and development in the creative phase.



Idea Generation for Centerpiece Content (continued)

If at a loss for inspiration, create a statement that carefully defines a problem prospects and customers are trying to solve. A well-formed problem statement can spark creative ideas in the context of 'helping prospects.' A golden rule of earned media is that slick self-serving advertising copy will never earn any relevant media placement.

The best content ideas should:

- **Educate**
- **Solve a Problem**
- **Entertain**

Run final ideas by team members, clients and online influencers that fit the target persona profile. Ask them if the content is something that they would share within their networks. Be sure to ask yourself the same question. The net promoter score is a great framework for determining if a good idea would fly with a given target audience.

Once the idea has been thoroughly defined, it can then be handed off to creative to turn research into vivid reality.

CONTENT THAT IS SO HELPFUL

PROSPECTS

WON'T KNOW HOW THEY LIVED

WITHOUT IT



CREATIVE

The creative process sets the stage for the success or failure of an earned media campaign. If promoted content is not genuinely informative, educational and entertaining, online media outlets won't share it with their audiences or your prospects. Average content to the Internet is like sand to the desert: Completely unremarkable. Put maximum effort into creating remarkable content that really stands out, and it will earn media placements and be shared socially.

It's also important to note that the creative process costs must be managed closely to maximize an earned media campaign's return. Many times, the design and development costs can mean the difference between hitting a grand slam and barely sliding into first. There are several steps that a marketing team can take in the design and development phase to manage costs.



Design and Development of Centerpiece Content

Document and plan content design by whiteboarding ideas in a mind map format. A mind map allows a marketing team to focus on the central theme, while organizing ideas in a non-linear fashion and grouping topics by subject, rather than chronologically.

Team members may find that this spatial organization of ideas is much more intuitive than an outline or traditional note-taking. The final mind map should contain a high-level view of all of the components necessary to create remarkable content.

Content for earned media is meant to be shared by specific online properties. The best way to ensure this happens is to solicit input from high-ranking community influencers during the design and development process. This will generate buy-in from these influencers, as they become real stakeholders in the process.



Design and Development of Centerpiece Content (continued)

Influencers are usually experts who will help keep design on track with what their community members really want. Involving community influencers in the design process takes a lot of networking, but this investment will pay off down the road when influencers help with promotion.

It's important to keep lines of communication open between the team members and the selected online community influencers. However, it's also important to keep the process efficient. Make sure the influencers understand that their comments and input are valued but team members will make final decisions about content. These key stakeholders should be involved only in design ideation and first drafts.

The final draft sign-off should be approved by a team leader. This will avoid the problem of trying to "please everyone."

WHERE THE RUBBER MEETS THE ROAD



PROMOTION

If relevant content is the engine, then promotion is the gasoline. Having an “if you build it, they will come” mentality is great for the design phase, but the earned media process is about maximizing marketing ROI. The best way to propel a project off the ground like a rocket is to place teasers, guest blogs and interviews promoting centerpiece content in front of target personas.



Build the Teaser Article

Before promoting content, a general “teaser” article should be built that will serve as the delivery mechanism that explains to media outlets, communities and influencers the importance of the centerpiece content. In some cases, media outlets prefer to write the articles themselves. If this happens you don’t necessarily need a teaser article. However, offering media outlets something to start with in the form of a teaser article may help to communicate the most important points about the contribution.

The teaser article may also include a few highlights from the content. Don’t be afraid to share the best highlights, as this will drive users to want to find out more by downloading the centerpiece. Finally, never submit the same article to multiple media outlets. Duplicating content on the web will not only fail to specifically speak to each target community on an individual basis, it’s also bad Internet citizenship.



Influencer and Community Outreach

Start promotional outreach by reaching out to the key stakeholders that were involved in the design and development process. These online influencers will kick off promotion by sharing the centerpiece content within their online communities. Next, team members can reach out to industry associations. Contact key industry partners and request that the content be featured in the blog or news section of their websites. Involve your PR team for a coordinated effort announcing the centerpiece content's release.

Finally, reach out to and network with all of the influencers and owners of online communities identified in the research process. These communities will find the content familiar and valuable. Online influencers will share relevant, remarkable content with their online communities.

THIS IS WHAT WE'VE ALL BEEN WAITING FOR



CONVERSION

Achieving marketing goals is the primary function of an earned media campaign. This is the fun part: Marketing teams get to reap the rewards from a successful earned media campaign. Conversion goals, such as opt-in email list generation and purchases, are met in the short run, while traffic goals like keyword portfolio growth and organic search traffic are met over the long term. The immediate conversion goals focus on converting users with a targeted landing page.

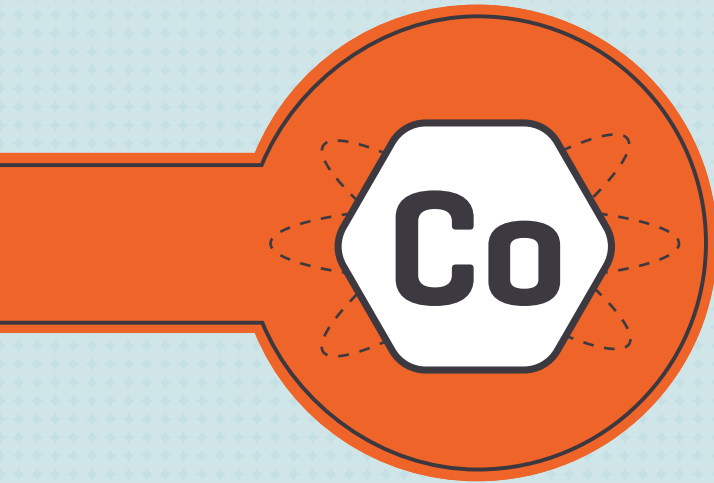


Building the Landing Page

A targeted landing page is necessary to provide a structured gateway that requires prospects to submit personal information, such as their email address and company name, to access the centerpiece content. This data will be used by marketing to fuel lead-nurturing campaigns, grow online communities or achieve other online marketing goals using a highly targeted audience interested in consuming company content.

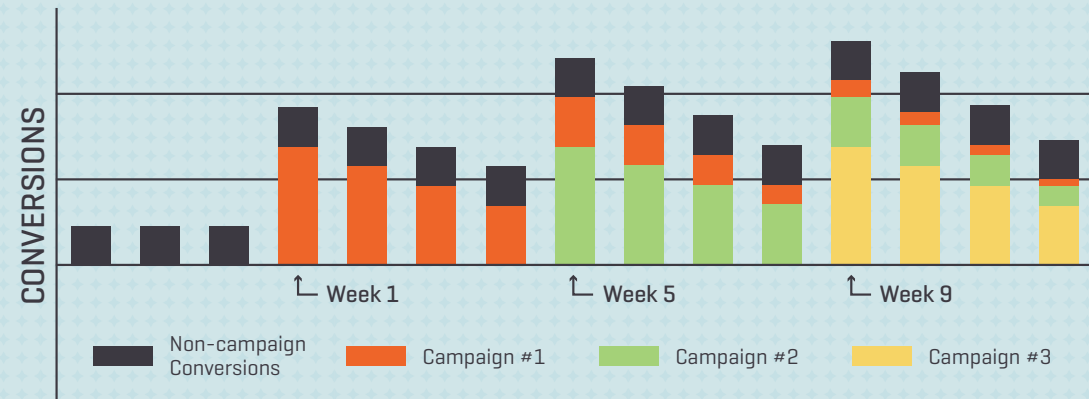
Start with the knowledge gathered from the research process to build a landing page with relevant value propositions. Include some of the main highlights that were featured in the teaser article, as well as graphics, videos or other media highlights from the centerpiece content. Keep all of the landing page content above the fold or within 625 vertical pixels. This will ensure that most users will see all offers, and contact and submission areas without having to scroll down the page.

It's also important to work with a reactive design that is optimized for multiple device types. Mobile and tablet versions of both the landing page and the centerpiece content can help reach more prospects.



Campaign Stacking Method

The earned media strategy is an ongoing effort that builds upon itself. Consistently deploying earned media campaigns can accelerate the timeline to reaching your web traffic and conversion goals. Due to the evergreen nature of earned media campaigns, it's easy to see how "stacking" these campaigns accelerates the accumulation of online conversions over the long term.



REVIEW

As practicing good SEO relies more on high-quality content and users ready to share it, embracing contribution and earned media strategies will be the best way to earn link referral traffic, social media buzz and community growth for your organization. These methods can also aid your opt-in email list growth, expand your network reach and boost your brand awareness. In an industry where audiences and their needs change quickly, you'll need a future-proof strategy that works time after time.



DISCOVER WHAT EARNED MEDIA CAN DO FOR YOUR MARKETING EFFORTS



Get a **FREE EARNED MEDIA OPPORTUNITY ASSESSMENT**.

This report will give you a snapshot of the potential marketing opportunity your brand can realize through strategic content marketing and online PR.

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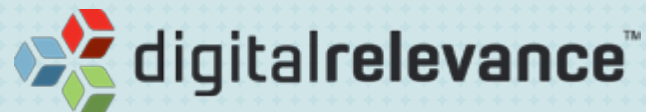
Contact Aaron Aders, Market Research Director and Co-founder at digitalrelevance™, to discover how your company can execute earned media campaigns.

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